COUNTRY REPORTS: BURUNDI

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Status report

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Implementation of Burundi's long-range development vision was pushed down to departmental level in mid-2026: on 3 July 2026 the Prime Minister instructed every ministry to produce its own implementation document for the Vision « Burundi émergent en 2040 et développé en 2060 », with digitalisation and e-government among the first priority programmes. The standing digital instrument they write against is the Plan Directeur de Digitalisation des Services Publics 2023-2033, adopted by the Council of Ministers on 10 May 2023, which carries broadband, cybersecurity, data centres and cloud, data protection, digital payments, digital signatures, quality of service and universal access in a single document. Sector policy above it is older: the Politique Nationale de Développement des TIC was adopted on 13 July 2011 for the period 2010-2025.

That policy's own term has now run out.

Much of what has followed sits at validation rather than in force. Burundi validated a National Data Governance Strategy in November 2025 with support from the UN Economic Commission for Africa, built on seven pillars including data management, quality and interoperability, with a three-year action plan still to be produced; the national validation session for an artificial-intelligence strategy opened on 21 April 2026, run by the Ministry of Finance, Budget and Digital Economy with UNDP. The pattern is long-standing: the broadband strategy Burundi Large Bande 2025 was validated by stakeholders on 6 December 2017 and was still awaiting government adoption in early 2018. The National Financial Inclusion Strategy 2015-2020, which prioritised the rural population, women, youth and micro and small entrepreneurs, has likewise run its course.

The money behind the digital programme reached a checkpoint in March 2026, when PAFEN, the World Bank-backed digital-economy foundations project, went through a formal mid-term review.

Legislation and regulation

Burundi acquired its first statute on personal data in 2026, and the government itself recorded the size of the gap being filled: adopting the bill on 22 October 2025, the Council of Ministers stated that Burundian positive law then held no legal regime for the processing of personal data. The National Assembly adopted it unanimously on 15 January 2026 and Loi n°1/03 portant protection des données à caractère personnel was promulgated on 10 March 2026.

It joined a thin digital legal layer, made up until then of the 2022 cybercrime statute and the 2024 electronic communications and postal code. Regulation of electronic commerce runs out of that code: the telecommunications regulator ARCT published national e-commerce guidelines on 29 May 2026, then called on e-commerce platforms and merchant sites on 26 June 2026 to make the compulsory prior declaration of conformity.

Payments rest on Loi n°1/07 du 11 mai 2018 portant système national de paiement, with the central bank's oversight framework of 20 November 2025 setting the licensing and sanction regime for payment service providers. For public-sector data the closest thing to enabling legislation is Décret n°100/085 du 25 juillet 2018, which defines administrative data and provides for electronic access with rules on confidentiality and security, and the statistical system is organised by loi n°1/08 du 20 mai 2021.

International connectivity is still governed by Décret n°100/166 du 26 mai 2015, a single-gateway regime for access to international telecommunications networks; an infrastructure-sharing law was still in draft in August 2026. Two ordinances adopted in 2026 govern quality of service and SIM cards, and the communications ministry convened creators, legal experts and jurists on 26 August 2026 to prepare a first bill on social-media influencers and content creators. SIM registration under the 2026 ministerial ordinance was about 70% complete on the regulator's count, reported 2 October 2026. The Senate adopted the access to information bill unanimously on 29 September 2026; promulgation is not on record.

Data protection

Burundi's first data-protection law is in force but the regulator it creates is not: the statute places the new authority under the Ministry of Digital Economy and restricts cross-border transfers of personal and sensitive data to jurisdictions without adequate protection or approved safeguards, while the authority's detailed operating mandate awaits an implementing decree. The law itself regulates collection and use by public and private bodies, sets out individual privacy rights and creates an independent supervisory authority, and it attaches criminal penalties. The agency it creates was not operating in April 2026, no adequacy list had been published, penalties are criminal only with no administrative fines, and there is no general requirement to store data in the country.

What it replaced was very little. Before 2026, confidentiality rested on scattered sectoral provisions — banking secrecy under the 2017 Banking Act, healthcare confidentiality rules, telecommunications privacy regulations and the 2022 cybercrime law — none of which imposed any duty to notify users, regulators or an authority after a breach.

The sequencing matters for what the law is for. Lawmakers tied the reform to the digitisation of the voter register, computerised public administration and preparations for the biometric national identity card, officials present it as removing a key obstacle to deploying the biometric card, and the interior ministry's own description of the order of work — legislation on personal data first, then the software platform — is that of an enabling instrument rather than a check on the identity programme it accompanies.

The first test of consent in practice has been run by the telecoms regulator rather than by the data-protection authority. ARCT issued injunctions to mobile operator Lumitel on 29 May 2026 requiring that subscription to value-added services be genuinely voluntary and preceded by notification of the subscriber; the consumer association ABUCO reported in July 2026 that unconsented enrolment had not measurably improved since, while Lumitel maintains that no such service is activated without a subscriber's deliberate action.

Regional collaboration

The rules most likely to reshape Burundi's data regime are being written regionally rather than nationally: East African Community rules on cross-border data flows and personal data protection had been approved by July 2026, but must still pass the bloc's decision-making organs before any partner state adopts them. Burundi has aligned itself with that direction, calling for harmonised data-exchange frameworks for interoperable cross-border public services at the EAC Digital for Development Forum in June 2026, the same week the regional Secure Data Sharing Framework went to a validation workshop in Dar es Salaam.

Other strands of the single digital market are at the same stage. A regional mobile roaming framework moved from agenda to development at meetings held 25-29 May 2026, and implementation support for the regional cross-border payments work comes from EARDIP, which supplies digital infrastructure and regulatory frameworks. On monetary integration the target for a single EAC currency was held at 2031 in July 2026, with the same committee recording that no partner state has attained all four primary macroeconomic convergence criteria and the agreed remedy being peer review for macroeconomic surveillance alongside operational frameworks for the 2026/27-2030/31 development strategy.

Burundi is well placed to absorb this: it belongs to COMESA, the East African Community and ECCAS, and scored 61.8 out of 100 for Regional Integration in 2023, seventh of 54 African states and its best-ranked measure in a business environment ranked 43rd. It also hosted the Central Africa Internet Governance Forum for the first time from 16 to 21 February 2026, bringing together eleven countries.

Bilaterally, Burundi names postal modernisation and internet infrastructure as its priorities with Vietnam, whose reciprocal ask is a wider role for Viettel's local operator Lumitel — a channel that runs on Burundi's side through the secretary general of the ruling CNDD-FDD party.

Standards

Burundi is the East African Community's most diligent adopter of harmonised standards: it had taken up 628 of the 690 harmonized EAC standards as at June 2023, 91 per cent and the highest rate of the six partner states. Domestically the founding instrument is the National Quality Policy adopted by the Council of Ministers on 2 February 2022, which sets the objectives, roadmap and timetable for the national quality-infrastructure system, and the standards body BBN signed a protocol with the Democratic Republic of the Congo's Office Congolais de Contrôle on 29 August 2025 covering standardisation, metrology, conformity assessment and progressive mutual recognition of certificates. BBN is the country's ISO member body, participating in 11 technical committees and observing 28 (October 2026).

Sixty-two of the 690 harmonized East African Community standards remained unadopted as at June 2023. Beyond the quality policy, those EAC adoptions and the payment-messaging migration, the country's standards work since 2022 sits at validation, workshop or self-assessment stage rather than in force.

The clearest exception is in payments, where the central bank's Automated Transfer System completed its migration to the ISO 20022 messaging standard on 5 February 2026, with interbank operations resuming on the new standard the following day, two months before the instant payment system launched. In e-commerce, ARCT's May 2026 guidelines name interoperability, transparency, transaction security and online consumer protection as their standards.

Elsewhere the work is diagnostic. SETIC presented the final Concept type des Systèmes d'Information des institutions publiques — a cross-government technical standard permitting the adoption of international ICT standards — for validation on 17 December 2024, without a subsequent adoption act. A workshop held 7-10 April 2026 worked on common technical standards for exchanging health data, HL7 FHIR among them, and the education ministry opened a three-day self-assessment of its management information system against the African Union's continental EMIS norms on 9 June 2026.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The Senate unanimously adopted a law on access to public information on 29 September 2026, creating a National Commission on Access to Public Information that hears appeals and a duty to publish certain information within 30 days, with exceptions for national security, private life and ongoing judicial investigations and no statutory ceiling on

access fees, after the Council of Ministers adopted the draft on 10 June 2026. Promulgation is not on record and no text is published; the account rests on a Senate committee report that does not reproduce the exceptions chapter. That reticence is characteristic — Burundi sits among the weakest states in Africa both for the disclosure of public records and for citizens' ability to obtain them, and its media-freedom and free-expression scores each fell by about 12 points over the decade to 2023.

Online expression is policed directly. The media regulator suspended the online blogger coalition Yaga Burundi on 27 March 2025 as unregistered, and journalist Sandra Muhoza, convicted in December 2024 over comments in a journalists' WhatsApp group, remained in prison after an appeal court ruled on 30 May 2025 that the trial court lacked jurisdiction. Burundi fell 17 places to 125th of 180 in the 2025 press freedom index.

Formal participation channels exist mainly in local government, where the 2014 communal administration law requires plenary sessions of the communal council to be public and the council to hold meetings at least twice a year open to hill councils and local associations. Online, the clearest public consultation addressed to Burundians in the period was not the state's: the World Bank ran an open consultation on its Country Partnership Framework for Burundi from 21 April to 5 May 2026. Domestic policy work does consult — the National Data Governance Strategy was preceded by a multi-stakeholder consultation on 18 April 2025 ahead of its November validation workshop.

Debate on the newer questions is being carried outside government. The first documented workshop on AI governance and data ethics was held in Bujumbura in July 2026, convened by ABADAAD, the association of Burundian former DAAD scholarship holders, rather than by a regulator. On telecoms, the consumer association ABUCO has proposed états généraux de la communication, bringing authorities, operators, regulators and consumer organisations together to identify the root causes of service failure, its president noting that repeated appeals to the operators by the head of state and members of government have had no observable effect. For telecoms complaints the standing route is ARCT's free short code 151 and physical suggestion boxes in operator agencies, and the presidency has adopted the locally built messaging application Gasape Chat as a channel for citizens' grievances, beside the messaging platform and calls it already used (October 2026).

Finance

Financial sustainability

Burundi's treasury has taken on two large digital lines of its own in the 2026/27 budget law: BIF 27.1 billion from national resources for a new digitalisation directorate, BIF 17.4 billion of it for digitalising public services, and BIF 12.0 billion for the state ICT agency SETIC, BIF 10.1 billion of that for equipment (2026/27), against BIF 1.8 billion for SETIC a year earlier (2025/26).

National resources carry 28.6% of the digital lines of the 2026/27 budget law at the appropriation stage, BIF 78.1 billion of BIF 273.4 billion, up from 24.1% in 2025/26 and 26.2% in 2024/25; the rest is donor project money drawn through the budget (2026/27).

That donor side is two projects: BIF 105.4 billion for the World Bank-financed digital foundations project (2026/27) and BIF 89.8 billion for the East African Community regional statistics project (2026/27). The digital foundations project runs to 2028, and its state counterpart line was BIF 189.3 million in 2025/26 (2025/26). Execution of the 2025/26 budget is reported in-year, through the finance ministry's third-quarter return (July 2026).

Own-source money runs through the universal service fund: its revised 2026/27 procurement plan spends BIF 11.4 billion from the fund's own resources on dedicated internet transit for public health facilities, secondary schools and community telecentres (2026/27), after BIF 4.8 billion for three pilot digital villages in 2025/26 (2025/26). The state is also buying equity in the backbone: BIF 2.7 billion for a capital increase in the Burundi Backbone System in 2025/26, and the same again in 2026/27.

The plan behind it is costed. The public-services digitalisation master plan prices its programme at USD 111.9 million over 2023-2033 and provides for an e-government fund drawn from the national budget and development partners, to be governed by its own text.

MoUs and other agreements

The largest agreement on record is with the United States: a five-year health-sector memorandum signed on 6 February 2026 commits US$156m, health-data management included, and its data-systems section plans US$1,885,264 of United States funding for six named health data systems in 2026, falling each year to US$475,264 in 2030, subject to the availability of funds. The memorandum states that it is not an international agreement and gives rise to no legal rights or obligations.

Burundi opened talks with the International Finance Corporation in February 2025 on public-private partnership routes for its digital transformation agenda. Bilateral digital cooperation with Vietnam, taken up again in July 2026, puts postal-system modernisation and internet infrastructure on Burundi's side of the exchange and a wider role for Viettel's local operator Lumitel on Vietnam's. Outside the digital sector proper, the Chinese company IBI Crossborder announced on 3 July 2026 that it had signed a comprehensive mining cooperation agreement with the Burundi Mining Authority, presented as a chapter of the Digital Silk Road.

New investments

The largest single live digital commitment to Burundi is the World Bank's Digital Foundations Project, a USD 50 million IDA commitment running from 2022 to 2028, and a further USD 42 million of additional financing was approved in January 2024 to deepen it with an emphasis on modernising public financial management. Known in Burundi as PAFEN, the operation, approved in FY2022, stood at around US$92 million covering broadband, digital skills and public-service digitisation (May 2025).

The one private commitment of comparable size is older: Huawei financed a USD 30 million recovery plan for the state operator ONATEL, adopted by the Council of Ministers in November 2017, its repayment drawn from the revenues of ONATEL's mobile arm, revenues Iwacu reported in 2020 to be insufficient.

Five country-level digital commitments to Burundi are recorded, at a combined USD 142.6 million (October 2026): three from the World Bank at USD 107 million, the Huawei credit to ONATEL at USD 30 million and Lumitel's USD 5.62 million share of the rural 4G contract. A German development grant reaches the country only through a regional East African Community programme (October 2026).

Connectivity takes the largest share of the digital money committed to Burundi, ahead of government technology and public financial management, with the ONATEL credit third and digital payments fourth.

The money arrives mostly as sovereign concessional lending to the Republic of Burundi, with one vendor credit to the state operator, one commitment structured as a public-private partnership and the only grant money arriving through a regional programme.

The programme is now spending. An integrated public financial management system, SIGFP_BI, is being acquired under the IDA grants that finance PAFEN (March 2026), virtualisation and backup equipment for SETIC is being procured under the same programme (April 2026), and Lumitel signed a PAFEN contract at the Ministry of Finance in March 2026 as a public-private partnership pairing World Bank money with the operator's own investment. A digital payment delivery component also sits within the World Bank's USD 150 million Cash for Jobs Project, approved in December 2021 and supporting mobile money and digital cash-for-work payments.

Germany's BMZ has committed EUR 5 million to the East African Community for a regional artificial intelligence research and training network and digital skills across the partner states, Burundi among them (August 2026), and Viettel undertook in December 2025 to double the investment it makes through Lumitel. No venture capital or angel investment was available to digital entrepreneurs when the World Bank assessed the digital economy in 2020.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Lumitel, Viettel's Burundian operator, launched 5G on 19 December 2025 and had installed 80 sites across the seven former provinces by February 2026, ahead of a working 3G layer: on the regulator's own coverage figures 2G reaches 97% of the population, 3G around half and 4G around a third (February 2026).

About 11.3% of the population were internet users in January 2024, and penetration was still about 12.5% in 2025, among the least-connected on the continent. ARCT states that the national territory is covered by fibre, counting 1,750km on the BBS backbone reaching all provinces, 350km on ONATEL's metropolitan network in Bujumbura and 3,400km operated by Viettel (December 2024). In 2019 Burundian ISPs were using about 2.3 Gb of the 7.1 Gb of international bandwidth they had already bought.

Landlocked Burundi reaches submarine capacity on the EASSy, SEACOM and TEAMS systems through neighbouring countries' landings rather than any of its own (2020), with regional fibre connection points into Rwanda, the DRC and Tanzania, and the Council of Ministers adopted a memorandum on a further fibre interconnection project with the DRC on 8 May 2024. One of those routes has a published capacity and it has just moved: Tanzania's state operator and the Burundi Backbone System agreed to raise capacity on the Tanzanian route from 4Gbps to 10Gbps (September 2026), framed as a response to demand for cross-border digital services. No capacity figure is published for the Rwandan or Congolese routes. Domestically the internet exchange point BDIXP has nine members (2026), under a 2014 decree vesting the national exchange point in the state and putting the keeping of local traffic off international links first among its objectives.

ARCT accepts that internet quality is disrupted at times, attributing it to power cuts, generator fuel, unstable supply from the utility REGIDESO, urban bandwidth saturation, ageing transmission equipment and missing masts (August 2026), and outages are driven by electricity, fuel and foreign-exchange shortages (2025). An instruction in January 2025 required operators to improve service quality and accessibility.

Two rural contracts followed under the PAFEN programme: USD 10 million with Lumitel to extend 4G in rural areas, reaching 86 collines (March 2026) and USD 5.9 million for the state operator ONATEL to cover 92 more (April 2026). ARCT counts three mobile operators, Econet Leo, Viettel Burundi and ONATEL, alongside the satellite ISPs Starlink and NT Global (December 2025), and an ITU-backed national broadband-mapping project was launched in October 2025. The state replaced the Director General of the backbone concessionaire BBS on 9 April 2026 and its board representatives four days later.

Data Storage

Government hosting in Burundi rests on a single small network operations centre and data centre run by the state ICT agency SETIC (May 2022), and there is no shared government facility: the revenue authority, the central bank and the Presidency each run their own (2020). Building a national data centre was named a priority of the World Bank-financed Digital Foundations project at its mid-term review (March 2026).

Commercially the picture is thinner still. Bujumbura holds small-scale colocation sites — Lacell SU's Smart Burundi and the Burundi Backbone System — with no hyperscale or major regional colocation operator present and no direct cloud on-ramps to AWS, Google Cloud or Microsoft Azure, so traffic is typically routed via Nairobi (2025). BBS does host a national data centre that other public agencies use to back up their systems.

Capacity is being added one institution at a time. The Bank of the Republic of Burundi put maintenance of parts of its physically separate alternative site at Rumonge out to open international tender, financed from its own funds (November 2025); the Agence de Développement du Burundi tendered for racks, voltage stabilisers and projectors for its own facility (February 2026); and PAFEN re-issued a tender for virtualisation and backup equipment and licences for SETIC, the body hosting the national digital platforms, in April 2026.

That same SETIC facility is what the national AI strategy's cloud and data-hub pillar is built on (April 2026), while the 2026 data protection law restricts transfers of personal data to jurisdictions without adequate protection or approved safeguards — a constraint on offshore hosting whose administration waits on an implementing decree.

Energy

Burundi commissioned the Mulembwe hydropower dam on 16 June 2026, adding 17MW and completing the 49.5MW Jiji-Mulembwe complex, built at USD 320 million with African Development Bank, World Bank and European Union finance — an addition against total installed capacity of 204.882 MW (September 2025). It arrives after a multi-day blackout across Bujumbura and several provinces while a new substation was connected to the grid (August 2025).

The national energy compact records an electricity access rate of 25.9 per cent, 8 percentage points of it grid connections and 17.9 points decentralised supply (September 2025), against a commitment to reach 70 per cent by 2030 and deploy 300 mini-grids and a stated financing requirement of USD 3.49 billion. Access was 65.0 per cent in urban areas against 2.3 per cent rural in 2023, and Burundi's Access to Energy score stood at 3.2 out of 100, 53rd of 54 African states that year.

More than two-thirds of the access that exists is off-grid, and reaching the 2030 target means a rise of 44.1 percentage points from the September 2025 baseline — close to tripling access in around five years.

Delivery is split between REGIDESO, the national utility, and ABER, the rural electrification agency, with an electricity bill passed by the Senate in December 2023 that would open rural mini-grid development to private investors (April 2024). REGIDESO signed the implementation contract for component 1 of ASCENT Burundi on 17 June 2026, covering nationwide reinforcement of the 30kV network, with the Bujumbura urban network, a private distribution operator pilot and institutional support to the ministry and the regulator AREEN still to come; the Rubirizi substation is connected to the 110kV Gahongore-RN1 line and can carry up to 50MW into Bujumbura (August 2025). ABER electrified ten rural centres in its 2025-26 year with works continuing at seven more and maintains solar mini-grids and micro-hydro plants alongside them.

For telecommunications the connection runs the other way: of the three remedies to connectivity failure in train, a study on powering mobile sites is still only planned (August 2026).

Technical Capacity

Burundi's meteorological agency IGEBU attributes a months-long outage of its automatic weather-station network to expired SIM cards, unpaid mobile data plans and a lack of basic maintenance (September 2025) — recurrent costs, not equipment, taking a national data service off the air.

The three institutions that run the digital estate — the communications ministry MINCOTIM, the state ICT agency SETIC and the regulator ARCT — were each assessed as needing technical assistance to carry out their mandates (May 2022), when the government network COMGOV connected around 55 public institutions at 2.5 Mbps and there was no national data-exchange layer joining government systems to one another. On the World Bank's statistical performance measure, data sources are the weakest pillar by a wide margin (2023).

There is capacity where an operation has been run long enough to build it. The interior ministry states that travel-document production is entirely nationally operated since the Contec Global contract lapsed, with a new, cheaper supplier contracted for production inputs (March 2023), and civil registry agents were to be trained to run newly acquired biometric identity equipment as the rollout extended beyond 11 pilot communes (December 2023). IGEBU also holds the national mapping mandate and describes mapping work using remote sensing, GPS, geographic information systems and drones (August 2026). The publicly visible software developer community is small, a few low-activity groups in Bujumbura (2025), though one domestic producer ships an AI product built in the country (February 2026).

Training is running alongside the systems it serves: tertiary ICT and computer science degrees at a handful of Burundian universities (2025), digital-skills training for the civil servants who manage PAFEN's shared infrastructure, a finance ministry change-management workshop held from 7 April 2026 to prepare the administration for the SIGFP financial management system, and education ministry cadres trained in database administration in Yaoundé in May 2026. An AfDB-financed project tendered in June 2026 for equipment for the Rusi polytechnic centre and ten rural digital learning centres. The state ICT secretariat SETIC lists software development for public institutions, a network operations centre, hosting of national platforms and maintenance of public networks and systems among its own services (October 2026), though the existing finance system shows the reach of that support: a court of accounts audit debated in January 2024 found the SIGEFI link at the infrastructure ministry not functional, its staff travelling to the finance ministry to use it. The interior ministry itself names thin infrastructure and technical capacity among the remaining constraints on civil-registry digitisation (August 2026).

Cybersecurity

Burundi's Council of Ministers adopted a national cybersecurity strategy on 14 October 2026, providing for a legal and institutional framework, protection of critical infrastructure and of public data, and a national team to coordinate incident response. That team has been a decade in coming: an ITU project from 2013 to 2022 procured its equipment in 2017 and renovated its premises in 2019, and closed with it not fully operational.

The Bank of the Republic of Burundi confirmed that €814,957.821 of its funds was stolen in June 2024 by attackers who infiltrated the computer system of a partner bank in Poland; the money had not been recovered and no suspect had been publicly identified, and the bank said it would reinforce its security and prevention mechanisms (September 2026). Burundi sits in the lowest tier of the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index (2024). The legal layer consists of a stand-alone cybercrime statute, Loi n°1/10 of 16 March 2022, recorded as in force on the government legal database, the 2024 electronic communications and postal code, Loi n°1/22 of 22 August 2024, and the personal data protection law, Loi n°1/03, promulgated on 10 March 2026. Before that law, confidentiality rested on scattered sectoral provisions — banking secrecy, healthcare rules, telecommunications privacy and the cybercrime law — none of which imposed a duty to notify anyone after a breach.

Institutional work runs ahead of the capacity measure. Cybersecurity is one of the strands of the World Bank's Digital Foundations project, which runs to 2028; it is named as a central focus of the e-KORI tax system's phased design; and a border management system at Bujumbura's international airport reads and verifies passports with a direct interconnection to Interpol (August 2025). Regionally, East African Community central bank governors flagged cybersecurity risk to the financial system as needing stronger common measures in July 2026.

DPI

Data Exchange

The one part of the Burundian state where systems pass data to each other automatically is trade administration: the revenue authority's web-based Guichet Unique électronique, launched in February 2026, connects the OBR, the pharmaceuticals and food regulator ABREMA and the ASYCUDA World customs platform, so importers obtain permits and pay fees online while the agencies share the data. From 4 August 2026 commercial applicants for a tax number are routed through the Agence de Développement du Burundi's easybusiness.bi portal, which passes their data to e-KORI automatically.

Beneath that there is no national exchange layer. The platform meant to supply one remains under development under the World Bank-financed PAFEN project, whose March 2026 mid-term evaluation recorded 61% of the budget engaged, with a national data centre, the identity rollout and public finance digitisation as its priorities, and no operational, API-based exchange connects the identity system to other government systems. The joins that exist are procedural, not technical: registering for a tax identification number requires a copy of the applicant's national identity card, but there is no database-level linkage between the tax register and the identity system, and a 2024 tax administration assessment found taxpayer registration not integrated with the filing and payment modules alongside it.

Outside customs the one working cross-sector link is a pilot: since October 2023, 52 health facilities in Kirundo province have registered births and issued birth certificates at the point of vaccination, at around 600 a month (January 2025).

The enabling instrument is a statistical one: Décret n°100/085 of 25 July 2018 defines administrative data, brings it into the national dissemination regime and provides for electronic access to it. A national data governance strategy was validated in November 2025, its action plan still to be produced. Regionally, East African Community rules on cross-border data flows and personal data protection had been approved by July 2026 but must still pass the bloc's decision-making organs, and a Secure Data Sharing Framework went to a validation workshop in Dar es Salaam in June 2026.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Burundi's biometric identity card is still not a document anyone can hold. The interior ministry presented the digital civil-registration and biometric identity platform on 6 May 2026, declaring itself technically ready to produce cards, but production awaits adoption of the law governing their use. The plan set in December 2023 to extend biometric registration from 11 pilot communes to the whole country before the 2025 elections was not met: thirteen communes were running biometric civil registration by August 2026.

What is in use is paper. The national identity card is a paper credential, mandatory from age 16, with no unique number and no central electronic database behind it; a 2018 World Bank estimate put roughly 27% of the population unregistered. The electoral commission confirmed in May 2024 that the biometric card would not be ready for the 2025 voter enrolment, falling back on the existing card it called easily falsifiable.

The system authenticates nothing. An October 2024 assessment records no digital authentication, no login to government portals, no way for an individual to see the data held on them and no know-your-customer validation for banks, and no dedicated digital identity regulation, the card's legal basis resting on civil registration law. The government's own portal states that further legal texts remain to be adopted to institute the national identification file, and the data protection law adopted on 15 January 2026 was framed as clearing an obstacle to the card rather than a check on it.

Burundi told the African Registrars General on 18 July 2026 that manual civil registration persists, that there is no single national civil-status database, and that it is not yet interoperable with the future digital identity system. Birth registration for under-fives stood at 83.5% in the 2016-17 demographic and health survey. A joint ministerial order of 10 June 2024, launched nationally that October, brings birth registration into health facilities, after a Kirundo pilot raised registration there from 8% to 45% between March 2023 and March 2024.

Refugees are already enrolled biometrically: ONPRA, the refugee office under the interior ministry, records asylum claims in the proGres database, enrols claimants in the BIMS fingerprint and iris system and issues refugee identity cards. The finance ministry's procurement plan for 2026-27 carries a contract to set up a national digital identity system at BIF 8,902,999,980, by open international tender on the state budget.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Burundi's national instant payment system, BurundiPay, was launched by the central bank on 23 April 2026, making banks, microfinance institutions and mobile money operators interoperable and Burundi the 22nd African state with a live instant payment system. The government named Lumicash, Ecocash, E-noti and Cashtel as the mobile money services it interconnects (June 2026). Of 78 financial institutions licensed to take part, 17 had put the system into service for their customers — five commercial banks, ten microfinance institutions and two payment institutions — with about 224,000 users and about BIF 4.29 billion transacted in total (4 August 2026).

The system arrived five months after the central bank's own deadline: full interoperability was promised for November 2025 and delivered in April 2026.

The switch underneath has not moved as fast. Modernisation of the national switch, BI-Switch, stalled after the central bank nationalised it in 2024, and in 2022 it connected 9 of 14 commercial banks and 2 of 41 microfinance institutions, with Ecocash and Lumicash still in integration testing. Demand is thinner than the plumbing: access to banking services scored 3.1 out of 100 in 2023, 50th of 54 African states and essentially unchanged over the preceding decade, and 31% of the country's 4.64 million mobile money subscribers were active in 2021.

Account opening remains a documentary exercise. There is no centralised identity database that financial institutions can use for know-your-customer validation and no online or e-KYC in the regulatory framework, and bank and mobile money accounts can be opened with the national identity card. A central bank anti-money-laundering regulation of 30 January 2026 and five implementing circulars, one of them on customer identification, tightened due diligence across the supervised financial sector.

The state's one digital disbursement channel of any size is social protection: the Merankabandi programme, built on a unified social registry, the CORE-MIS platform and digital payments, delivered emergency support to more than 100,000 households during recent floods and food crises (May 2026). Across borders, the central bank has acceded to the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System, with four Burundian banks authorised to take part (August 2026). Within the region, Tanzania and Rwanda are integrating their instant payment systems under the regional payments masterplan (July 2026), and the central bank told the regional central-bank governors it expects to join the East African cross-border payment system by December 2026.

The East African Legislative Assembly's accounts committee reported on 8 October 2026 that components of the regional payment-systems integration project were unfinished when its grant closed in June, and recommended an audit and a costed completion plan; the central bank said it remains committed to joining the East African Payment System by December.

Registries

The state is now counting the urban stock: RPPCUB-2026, a digitised and geo-referenced census and register of property owners in urban centres, was officially launched on 14 July 2026, its first phase covering Muha, Mukaza, Ntahangwa, Gitega, Ngozi and Rumonge on a budget of around 3 billion BIF. A joint ministerial ordinance of 6 February 2026 sets the terms on which the secured electronic land title is acquired, and the land titles and cadastre directorate launched an electronic document and records management system in June 2025 that is integrated with the building permit and property management systems.

The social register is the fullest of them: the Registre Social Unique under Merankabandi II had enrolled 249,671 households from targeted areas against a final target of 290,000 by June 2026, under a programme covering all 3,044 collines and quartiers.

Business registration runs through easybusiness.bi, the development agency's online single window, and persons and companies registered before the agency's digital immatriculation platform are being re-registered onto it, with the deadline extended by notice (June 2026). Since 4 August 2026 every tax registration request must go through e-KORI, with individuals attending in person for fingerprint and photograph capture before a certificate issues.

Civil registration is the register that has not consolidated. Births, deaths and marriages are registered and held locally at communal état civil offices, with no single nationwide repository; rural offices work entirely on paper, against a UNDP-supported commune-level digitisation pilot in Gitega. Direct birth declaration at the point of health-facility notification, piloted since 2023 and institutionalised in 2024, is live in 123 health facilities and has recorded over 52,000 births. The electoral register recorded 6,013,498 voters ahead of the 2025 legislative elections against a voting-age population of around 7.1 million. The finance ministry's procurement plan for 2026-27 carries a digital cadastre at BIF 2,692,493,969, with a secure network linking four land offices to a central data centre, and the electoral commission plans partial voter registration in October 2026 in more than 4,000 centres.

Sectoral management information systems

Burundi's health systems still do not talk to each other. Computerised hospitals still re-enter their data into DHIS2 by hand because automatic transfer from the hospital management system does not work (2019), and there is no unified digital identifier linking patients across providers. The health ministry is working under its information development plan for 2026-2028 to make DHIS2, SIDAInfo and OpenClinic interoperable using the HL7 FHIR standard, with no public timeline or budget confirmed. The exchange actually in service is narrow: UNDP deployed the DataToCare laboratory system into nine sites in May 2026, interconnecting ten diagnostic instruments with automated transmission of results, financed by the Global Fund.

Tax is the sector furthest along and still incomplete. The revenue authority launched the implementation phase of e-KORI on 19 January 2026 with a 27-month change-management rollout from 25 February, and about 13,000 electronic billing machines had been deployed against a target of 40,000 by June 2026 — against 500 delivered out of 10,000 ordered by December 2024. Managers of public funds must obtain an electronic-billing-machine invoice from their suppliers before paying them, on pain of a 20% penalty (September 2025). Public financial management itself has been tendered rather than built: an integrated system, SIGFP_BI, went out to tender in March 2026.

Elsewhere records are still fragmented. The education management information system produces detailed annual yearbooks but is not integrated with human resources, infrastructure or examinations records. Prosecutors failed to open case files or lost them, and magistrates cited heavy backlogs and improper police documentation for missed hearings (2024), while the justice programme's digitisation component has deployed scanning kits and an offline platform for digitising and classifying pending case files of the Cour suprême, the cours d'appel, and the tribunaux de grande instance and parquets of four provinces (June 2026). Machine learning appears only against malaria: AI-assisted reading of rapid diagnostic tests was piloted in Cibitoke and Kirundo from October 2024 and a national malaria data warehouse is being built with the malaria programme and the health ministry, alongside a pilot of the HealthPulse AI tool for reading rapid tests (March 2026). A platform to link the penal chain from the judicial police to the prisons was reported in preparation in October 2026, and the 2026-27 procurement plan carries an international traffic audit platform at BIF 6,691,559,485. The memorandum with the United States committed the government to DHIS2 as its national health data warehouse, with US$188,526 of support costed for 2026. The Belgian development agency reported that the health ministry validated the priorities of its health informatics plan for 2025 to 2027 on 22 July 2025.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Burundi's level on the UN E-Government Development Index fell from middle to low in the 2024 survey, placing it among the lowest-ranked countries in the world. Its public administration score was 47.6 out of 100 in 2023, 32nd of 54 African states.

What runs, runs at the revenue authority. The OBR announced on 17 February 2026 the launch and operationalisation of ABREMA, a fully digital one-stop shop for pharmaceutical imports — a platform first launched in 2021, with its exclusive use required from 18 February 2026. Alongside it sit e-KORI, launched on 19 January 2026 for tax filing and the payment of taxes and fees, delivered in nine phases with each deliverable validated before the next begins, and the older Umutangakori online filing and payment service.

Beyond tax the estate is thin. The immigration authority has run an online portal for passports, laissez-passer and visas since October 2022, and a Border Management System is live at Melchior Ndadaye international airport, automating passport reading and verification with a direct interconnection to Interpol, with extension to other posts announced. A government employment platform, PAEEJ-JOB, matched jobseekers with employers through a searchable CV database and vacancy listings (2025), and the justice ministry's digitalisation programme, costed at around 20 billion Burundian francs (2022), depended on a donor mobilisation strategy. Electronic procurement is at tender: the digital-foundations project issued an international request for proposals on 23 September 2026 for an end-to-end electronic procurement system, to be built over 18 months with the procurement regulator, and the finance minister puts its entry into force from 2027.

Ambition sits in policy. The master plan for the digitalisation of public services 2023-2033 is the standing instrument; the prime minister instructed every ministry on 3 July 2026 to produce its own implementation document for the Vision 2040/2060, with digitalisation and e-government among the first priority programmes; and a UNDP review in July 2026 found Burundian public data largely under-used and not yet fit for advanced analytical use.

The government service platforms on record as operating belong to the revenue authority. The presidency adopted a locally built messaging application as a channel for citizens' grievances, with no terms disclosed and no rule stated on control of the servers (2026).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The fullest digital operating model in Burundian local government is in land. A national technical manual issued by the Prime Minister's Office through the National Land Commission in November 2024 governs how communal land services and zonal land counters are run, down to premises, IT equipment, staffing and the handling of certificates and registers, and it provides for tablet-based field collection of land data and for the electronic production and archiving of land certificates at commune level.

Civil registration is the other function reaching the commune. The interior ministry presented its digital civil-registration platform on 6 May 2026, naming electricity and internet coverage at registration centres among the challenges, with biometric enrolment now running in a first group of communes and services being decentralised towards zone level (August 2026). A digitised and geo-referenced register of urban property owners was launched on 14 July 2026 across a first phase of urban communes.

Nothing yet moves commune data to the centre across sectors. The interior ministry presented a DHIS2-based platform for doing exactly that at a workshop on 12 March 2026; it was presented, not deployed, after preparatory work running since 2024, and participants named internet availability and technology infrastructure as the constraints on rolling it out across the country.

That gap is old. The multiservice telecentre planned for every commune and the government intranet and e-government services had not been delivered as at 2020, although national broadband infrastructure had reached commune level, while the government's own communications network was described at the same time as not functioning effectively in most government units.

The statutory frame long predates any of it. The 2014 communal administration law creates consultative development committees at commune, colline and quartier level that meet quarterly and advise on development planning and requires each commune's development plan to be formally approved and coherent with the national development plan. The map beneath it has since changed: a 2025 reform consolidated the 18 provinces into 5, and UNDP handed vehicles to provincial governors and 165 laptops, 165 power supplies, 68 printers and 68 photocopiers to communal administrations (August 2026).

In Kayanza commune 48 of 54 revenue collectors used point-of-sale machines in 2024-25, with takings transferred electronically to the commune's account (June 2025). Butihinda commune trained its planning, finance and accounting staff on 5 May 2026 to use Interbank Burundi's IBB M+ platform for communal revenue.

Rural digital data capture

Burundi's largest exercise in rural electronic data capture was a public health campaign: the 2025 mass distribution of insecticide-treated bednets registered households electronically at the door, managed stock by barcode and QR code, and tracked distribution in real time.

The standing systems that collect data from rural Burundi every year do not work that way. The annual school census is collected on paper at the school and entered electronically only at central level (December 2023). Civil registry services are being digitised with UNDP support, so that a record can be found by name and acts are no longer at risk of loss (January 2025).

What is arriving is equipment rather than systems. An African Development Bank-financed project tendered in June 2026 for IT equipment for the Rusi polytechnic centre and ten rural digital learning centres, including tablets for data collection, and UNICEF sought suppliers in August 2026 for computers and power units for écoles centrales in the former provinces of Kirundo, Muyinga and Gitega.

Most of the money is going into coverage first. SETIC signed a US$5,907,000 contract with the state operator ONATEL on 29 April 2026 to bring network coverage to 92 collines that have neither 2G nor 3G, serving 372,035 people; it is the second award under a PAFEN programme tendering 178 collines in three phases to reach around 786,000 people, with open-access national roaming as a condition (March 2026), the first having gone to Lumitel at more than US$10 million for 86 hills (March 2026).

That prices rural coverage at roughly US$64,000 per colline (April 2026) — the country's own smallest administrative division, and the delivery unit the contract itself uses.

Technology

AI

Burundi has taken its artificial-intelligence strategy out looking for money: the finance and budget minister presented its ambitions at the Korea-Africa economic cooperation ministerial in Seoul, seeking the financing and partnerships to turn it into concrete projects (September 2026), and no commitment, partner or project came out of it on the record. What the strategy is working against is a United Nations Development Programme review published in July 2026, which found Burundian public data largely under-used and not yet fit for advanced analytical use. The strategy itself was validated on 22 April 2026 by the Ministry of Finance, Budget and Digital Economy with UNDP support, at a session that opened the previous day, and follows an AI readiness diagnostic completed with UNDP in November 2025. It rests on six pillars — governance and ethics, sovereign cloud and data hubs, education and research, innovation and incubators, human capital, and sectoral pilots in health and agriculture — is framed around digital sovereignty, with its cloud and data-hub pillar built on the SETIC national data centre, and commits to training public officials in artificial intelligence. The November 2025 readiness assessment put establishing a legal framework for artificial intelligence among its three pillars.

Two artificial-intelligence deployments inside Burundian sectoral systems are on record as at September 2026, both in malaria control and both at pilot stage, against the strategy's plan for roughly fifteen health and agriculture pilots.

Both sit in the health ministry's malaria programme: AI-assisted reading of rapid diagnostic tests, piloted with Enabel and PNILP from October 2024, and a national malaria data warehouse under construction by Bluesquare.

The constraint is the data underneath. UNDP records that institutions produce more data than before but that it remains largely under-used and often unfit for advanced analytics, and practitioners at a July 2026 Bujumbura workshop on AI governance and data ethics, convened by the DAAD alumni association ABADAAD rather than by a regulator, put it more sharply: the country holds a great deal of information but very little structured, consented and usable data. Personal data protection is legislated, but one of those participants held that without organised, consented data even well-intentioned AI tools struggle to function, let alone fairly.

The rest reaches Burundi through the East African Community, where AI sovereignty is being worked up as a bloc-wide position and the 2025 pilot of a regional AI innovation challenge drew 3,891 participants from 57 universities across eight partner states, Burundi among them.

ICT Industry

Burundi's e-commerce sector is being held to a licensing gate: on 26 June 2026 the telecoms regulator ARCT called on platforms and merchant sites to make the compulsory prior declaration of conformity, on the basis of guidelines the regulator issued on 29 May 2026 setting technical and operational standards for national e-commerce and of the 2024 electronic communications and postal code. The sector is regulated out of the electronic communications and postal code by the telecoms regulator.

The supply side is thin and foreign-owned at the top. The market ARCT counts holds three mobile operators — Econet Leo, Viettel Burundi and ONATEL — alongside the satellite ISPs Starlink and NT Global, with Viettel's Lumitel ten years in the country as of December 2025 and the group undertaking at that anniversary to increase its Burundian investment.

Below the operators there is at least a domestic software layer rather than only imported systems and donor builds: a Burundian producer ships a machine-learning application built in the country that diagnoses crop diseases for farmers, and two further locally built artificial-intelligence products are on record, the mining-governance and geospatial tool MineGuard and AfriPrompt.

Extractives are the other route by which digital capability is being contracted in. The comprehensive mining cooperation agreement between the Burundi Mining Authority and the Chinese company IBI Crossborder, announced on 3 July 2026, is stated by the company in explicitly digital terms — digital transformation of the mining value chain, data-driven mineral exploration and a platform connecting Burundi's minerals to markets.

Innovation ecosystem

Burundi's startup layer is countable on one hand: Dealroom tracked around three startups nationally and recorded no disclosed venture capital investment as at 2025, and the country ranked 127th in WIPO's 2024 Global Innovation Index, in the bottom quartile of ranked economies. Early-stage equity has been the missing piece throughout: the World Bank's digital economy assessment found no venture capital or angel investment available to digital entrepreneurs and described digital entrepreneurship as embryonic, with a single technology hub in the country as at 2020.

The hub layer has since grown into something real. AfriLabs lists four member organisations — Burundi Business Incubator, Maison de l'Entrepreneur, DICOS Incubator and Impact Hub Bujumbura — alongside independent initiatives including BujaHub, KIT-HUB, the Burundi Innovation Hub, an ITU WSIS Prize winner in 2023, and Kesho Innovation Center as at 2025. BujaHub runs incubation facilities in Gitega as well as Bujumbura, putting capacity in the political capital, and operates its Moonshot programme with the government, UNDP, the Youth Bank, the Women Investment Bank and the PAEEJ youth employment agency. The startup sector's actors, incubators, access to finance and regulatory environment were mapped in the field in April 2023, for Orange Corners and the Netherlands Enterprise Agency.

Public money is starting to move through the same channels. The World Bank-financed PRETE-NYUNGANIRA project launched a national business-plan competition on 16 March 2026 to finance micro, small and medium enterprises, with ICT among its priority sectors, and the ICT secretariat SETIC opened the JuneTech digital festival on 24 June 2026 with the KiTHub innovation hub, backed by the World Bank-financed PAFEN programme. The national artificial-intelligence strategy's innovation pillar provides for incubators in Bujumbura, Ngozi and Gitega, which would extend the same pattern rather than change it.

Capacity

Literacy

Burundi's schools are getting better at holding on to the children they have and worse at recruiting them: the country's Education score rose 5.9 points over the decade to 2023, to 45.3 out of 100 and 37th of 54 African states, carried by education completion, up 12.6 points to 20.5, and education quality, up 11.8 to 44.2 — while over the same ten years enrolment moved the other way, down 1.4 points to 31.0 and 41st of 54.

The strongest part of the picture is the teaching force. Burundi's score for human resources in education — teacher supply and qualification — was 86.3 out of 100 in 2023, 24th of 54 African states and among the country's ten best-scoring indicators of any kind.

Digital literacy is handled as a component of a project rather than as a policy. PAFEN, the government's digital economy project, runs a digital access and inclusion component covering awareness-raising, access to devices and "culture numérique", aimed at rural communities, women and girls, and vulnerable groups; its published description sets out no baseline, no measurement instrument and no numeric target, so nothing in it states what the component is meant to achieve or by when.

The material reaching pupils outside the towns is donor-supplied and small. The EU's 2021-2027 programme for Burundi treats digital literacy as a cross-cutting provision alongside digital tools in education rather than as a priority area in its own right.

Training and skills

Burundi had 49 école-centrale computer centres equipped and functional against a national target of 760 school networks (March 2024), and the largest addition since is a procurement, not a delivery: UNICEF tendered on 11 August 2026 for 585 computers and UPS units across 39 écoles centrales in Kirundo, Muyinga and Gitega.

That tender works out at about fifteen machines per school, and even completed in full it would leave the equipped centres at well under a fifth of the 760-centre target.

At least three universities offer dedicated ICT and computer science degrees — the Université du Burundi's engineering faculty, Bujumbura Christian University and the Université du Lac Tanganyika — with no enrolment figures published for them (2025). The Ecole Normale Supérieure enrolled 347 computing students in 2023-24, 29 per cent of them women, and had put 203 Génie Informatique graduates onto the labour market since 2018-19 (March 2024). Burundi also held its second national coding camp for girls from 16 to 30 March 2026 under the African Girls Can Code Initiative, run by UN Women with three ministries and financed by Belgium.

Public-sector training runs through projects, not a standing programme. PAFEN's shared-infrastructure sub-component includes digital-skills training for the civil servants who use, manage and maintain that infrastructure, described without a target number, an obligation to attend or any certification. Departmental work is firmer: the finance ministry held a change-management workshop from 7 April 2026 to prepare the administration for the SIGFP public financial management system, and education ministry cadres were trained in database administration in Yaoundé in May 2026 as part of the education management information system's modernisation.

Burundi validated its first national strategy on open educational resources at a ministry workshop on 15-16 April 2026, framed as digitising the country's accumulated physical teaching materials onto a platform reachable by phone. Regionally, the communiqué of the second EAC regional education conference in Nairobi on 25-28 August 2026 tasks the EAC Secretariat with monitoring an accountability framework of country-owned targets to 2028, reviewed by regional peer review, and asks partner states to cascade those commitments to subnational level.

Research institutions

Burundi's academics, not its regulators, are convening the country's thinking on artificial intelligence: a workshop on AI governance and data ethics in the digitalisation era was held in Bujumbura in July 2026 by ABADAAD, the association of Burundian former DAAD scholarship holders, whose president is a professor.

The rest of the research footprint is regional. The 2025 pilot of the AI4EAC Innovation Challenge drew 3,891 participants from 57 universities across eight East African countries, Burundi among them; a second edition carries USD 50,000 in prize funding and adds Equity Group Holdings and the Karlsruhe Institute of Technology as partners (August 2026). The EAC AI Alliance was launched in March 2026 with an invitation to universities across the bloc, Burundi's among them, to join a regional network on artificial intelligence in education.

Inclusion

Access to services

Nothing in Burundian law or regulation requires a public service, a website or an e-government system to be usable by a person with a disability: the G3ict accessibility index records an absence of requirements across every assessed domain, with no universal service obligation covering disability and no accessible e-government or web-content rules (2025). The government's own report to the UN disability committee, covering 2014 to mid-2021, holds no data on the use of information and communication technologies by persons with disabilities (published October 2025), against a ratified UN convention and a 2018 law on the protection and promotion of their rights.

Access to public healthcare does not run on the identity credential at all: it runs on the Carte d'Assistance Maladie, a separate health-insurance card that became compulsory in February 2025 for adults not otherwise covered. The national card itself is a paper credential bought at the communal office, and the register behind it leaves a substantial share of the population unrecorded — so a household's route into a service is a stack of separate documents rather than one.

Grievance handling is sectoral rather than governmental. The regulator ARCT runs a free short code, 151, alongside physical suggestion boxes in operator agencies, covering telecoms consumer complaints only rather than acting as a cross-government grievance service (2024), and the revenue authority runs its own free helpline on short code 500 for e-KORI users (August 2026). The Ombudsman analysed and treated 776 case files during 2025, thirty of them carried over from 2024. What that machinery is not currently absorbing is cost: the consumer association ABUCO reports internet package tariffs rising steeply since 2025 (July 2026).

Participation has a statutory basis of long standing: the 2014 communal administration law requires plenary sessions of the communal council to be public and creates consultative development committees at commune, hill and neighbourhood level that advise on development planning. The clearest online consultation addressed to Burundians in 2026 was not the state's: the World Bank opened one on its 2026-2031 country partnership framework in April 2026. A community digital hub with shared computers and digital-literacy training opened at Shombo in August 2026; no user count or funding source is on file.

Digital divides

Burundi's divide is not principally a gender divide: equality of access to public services between women and men ranks first in Africa, while on the same index equality of socioeconomic opportunity sits near the bottom of the continent and fell sharply over the decade to 2023. The country now has an authoritative national measure of who is inside the financial system: ENIF 2024, the national financial inclusion survey run by the central bank with the national statistics institute and published in 2025, reports its results disaggregated by sex.

The floor under every other figure is income. GDP per capita was USD 199.6 in 2023, 52nd of 54 African states, on a GDP of USD 2.6bn for a population of 13.2 million. Against that, 88.7% of the population remained offline (January 2024), the gap between urban and rural electricity access is close to total (2023), and 5G arrived ahead of a working 3G layer for much of the country (February 2026). Power cuts and weak connectivity are among the main obstacles to rolling out the biometric identity card nationwide (May 2026), which is the same constraint appearing on the state's side of the counter.

The state's own plans concede the point: Burundi's artificial intelligence strategy was presented with low 4G coverage and weak rural electrification named as persisting challenges (April 2026), and the central bank's answer to thin smartphone ownership on its payment switch is to lean on USSD and offline transactions (April 2025). Where connectivity is a precondition of a service, exclusion is the norm: a survey of 17 centres for people with disabilities found 63% of users with no internet connection at all, with cost and network problems the barriers (December 2024). One dimension has moved the right way — equality in education improved over the decade to 2023 — even as enrolment moved the other way over the same period.

Data

National statistics

The weakest part of Burundi's statistical system is what goes into it: on the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators for 2023 the data sources pillar scores under 20%, with data services and statistical infrastructure in the 20-49% band, while data use and data products both score 70-89%. Burundi had fielded three or more household surveys in the preceding ten years but no labour force survey and no business survey at all, and no business or establishment census in twenty years. Mo Ibrahim's index put the capacity of the statistical system at 34.2 out of 100 in 2023, 43rd of 54 African states and 3.7 points down over the decade.

Statistical output rests on administrative records rather than survey rounds: three separately produced yearbooks — INSBU's national annuaire, the education ministry's and the trade, transport, industry and tourism ministry's — were published in the fourteen months to January 2026, all compiled from routine administrative sources.

INSBU published the 86th edition of the Annuaire Statistique du Burundi in December 2024, drawing 22 chapters from ministry administrative sources; the education ministry issued Tome 2 of its 2024-2025 education yearbook in December 2025, and the trade ministry its own 2024 edition in January 2026, built from licences, permits and traffic records. The national yearbook's foreword concedes difficulties often tied to insufficient collaboration with the administrations producing the figures.

Décret N°100/153 of 16 November 2022 replaced ISTEEBU with INSBU as the national statistical authority, technical coordinator of the Système Statistique National and permanent technical secretariat of the Comité National de l'Information Statistique, and charged with the national statistical development strategy. SNDS-III, a third-generation strategy, is in force, and its mid-term evaluation had reported by INSBU's second-quarter 2026 sector group meeting.

Burundi ran a general census of population, housing, agriculture and livestock in 2024, with preliminary results in 2025, though gaps stay visible from outside: the 2024 Ibrahim index carries no data at all for 16 of its 96 indicators, including every one of its 14 Afrobarometer public-perception measures. UNDP records data production rising but the output largely under-used and often unfit for advanced analytics.

Open data

Burundi's Council of Ministers adopted a draft law on access to public information on 10 June 2026, the first concrete legislative step towards a right-to-information regime the country has not previously had; the Senate adopted the bill unanimously on 29 September 2026, with exceptions for national security, private life and ongoing judicial investigations, and promulgation is not on record. It starts from a low base: in 2023 both the disclosure of public records and citizens' ability to obtain them ranked among the weakest in Africa.

What is published is middling rather than absent. In the 2024 Open Data Inventory, government finance and price statistics score 7.5 out of 10, labour 7, banking 6.5, international trade 6, balance of payments 5 and national accounts 4.5; environmental categories run from agriculture and land use at 7 through resource use at 6.5, energy and pollution at 6 each, to the built environment at 5.5; and social statistics run from health facilities at 7 down through education facilities and food security at 6, education and health outcomes, population, poverty and reproductive health at 5.5 each, gender at 5 and crime at 4.5.

Across the 23 data categories assessed for Burundi in the 2024 Open Data Inventory the average score is 5.7 out of 10, and no category reaches 8.

Where data is published, the terms are unusually permissive: material released on INSBU's open data platform carries a licence granting a worldwide, free and non-exclusive right to use, copy, modify, translate, publish, adapt, distribute and build derivative products from it, commercially or otherwise, subject to attribution. INSBU also validated a communication strategy for the national statistical system on 8 May 2026, aligned to East African Community guidelines, and a first national data governance strategy was validated at a workshop on 7 November 2025 with UN Economic Commission for Africa support. The constraint sits upstream of all of it: practitioners describe a country holding a great deal of information but very little structured, consented and usable data, which they identify as the limit on artificial intelligence.

Use of satellite data

Burundian weather observations reached international exchange for the first time on 4 September 2025, when IGEBU joined the WMO Information System 2.0 and began its transition from the legacy Global Telecommunication System — a connection that released a backlog of observations archived without international transmission since 2022. IGEBU also holds the national mapping mandate, so satellite work in Burundi is largely what IGEBU does.

On the meteorological side that means a public viewer: IGEBU publishes Meteosat Second Generation products over the Indian Ocean disc — precipitation rate combining geostationary infrared with low-earth-orbit microwave, High Rate SEVIRI 3.9µm imagery, a convection RGB product, natural-colour RGB and a cloud mask — updated automatically. IGEBU and the WMO held a launch workshop on impact-based forecasting in May 2026 under the WISER Action First project.

On the mapping side, IGEBU states that Burundian cartography has modernised through remote sensing, GPS, geographic information systems and drones, and names identifying and managing agricultural, urban and protected zones as one of its four stated purposes; a partnership with the Japan International Cooperation Agency has been updating the mapping of Bujumbura and Gitega since 2009. The largest current application is census geography: the Bureau Central du Recensement and IGEBU were, in February 2026, cleaning and updating the census cartography database, geoprocessing vector data and interpreting satellite imagery across 3,044 collines and quartiers.

Satellite connectivity is a separate matter and remains out of reach for most: Starlink has been licensed and operating in Burundi since 2024, but its equipment costs more than US$500, out of reach for many (September 2025).

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The United States signed a five-year health-sector memorandum with Burundi on 6 February 2026 committing US$156m, health-data management included. Its data-systems section names SIDAinfo as the electronic medical record, to reach 460 facilities by 2026 and 572 by 2028, and DHIS2 as the national health data warehouse, with United States funding for data systems planned at US$1,885,264 in 2026 falling to US$475,264 in 2030, and commits the government to pay the software licensing, cloud computing and hardware costs the United States does not.

The two governments intend to negotiate a data-sharing arrangement, expected to run for seven years, for exchanging data on the memorandum's performance and for accountability to the United States Congress; no such arrangement had been published as at October 2026. No hyperscaler activity in Burundi had been recorded as at October 2026.

China activities

China's newest engagement in Burundi is a mining cooperation agreement announced in July 2026 with the Burundi Mining Authority, whose stated objects are digital — digitising the mining value chain, data-driven mineral exploration, and a platform connecting the country's minerals to markets — and which the Chinese counterparty presents as Digital Silk Road work. Two months earlier the Chinese embassy handed ICT and production equipment to the state news agency, Agence Burundaise de Presse, on 28 May 2026.

The earlier work was in broadcasting. A Chinese satellite-television project completed in March 2019 equipped 300 Burundian villages with satellite reception under the "Access to Satellite TV for 10,000 African Villages" programme, financed through the South-South Cooperation Assistance Fund and delivering a pledge China had made at the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation. The largest Chinese money on record is commercial: Huawei extended a USD 30 million credit for a recovery plan for the state operator ONATEL, adopted by the Council of Ministers in November 2017 and meant to modernise the equipment of its mobile arm.

Of the four Chinese engagements on the record in Burundi's digital and media sector, two are completed transactions — the 2017 vendor credit to ONATEL and the 2019 satellite-television installation — and the other two are an in-kind equipment donation and a framework agreement with no recorded implementation. Two of the four were announced by Chinese state and Chinese corporate publishers; the 2026 equipment handover was reported by a Burundian institution and the ONATEL credit by a Burundian newspaper.

EU activities

The EU's Multiannual Indicative Programme for Burundi 2021-2027 gives digital no priority area of its own: it runs transversally across the programme's three priorities, appearing as digital literacy, context-adapted digital tools, digital tools in education and a stated "partnership for digital transformation".

The largest EU digital engagement now touching Burundi is therefore regional rather than bilateral. The EU-EAC DEEP programme — digital economy, e-commerce, e-payments and public e-services — was formally launched on 24 June 2026 and reaches Burundi as one of eight East African Community partner states, with no Burundi-specific component set out. Germany has separately put money into an EAC-wide artificial intelligence research and training network that reaches Burundi the same way (August 2026).

Bilaterally, what has arrived has come through other agencies. On 14 July 2026 the EU, working through UN Women, handed the government three digital platforms for handling gender-based-violence cases, along with a vehicle and seventeen motorcycles. EU money also sits behind the justice sector's judicial-statistics collection framework and structured case-file archiving in pilot areas (2024), and the EU was among the partners behind the Jiji-Mulembwe hydropower complex inaugurated in June 2026. Member-state money runs on the same pattern: Belgium funded the second national coding camp for Burundian girls in March 2026, implemented by UN Women with three ministries.

Gulf/UAE activities

Burundi's one recorded Gulf engagement in the digital sector is an announcement: a Qatari royal delegation leading the Al Massour Holding group, received by the President in August 2025, announced a decision to invest heavily in sectors including cybersecurity, digital transformation, telecommunications and banking. No Gulf or United Arab Emirates memorandum, framework agreement or loan on digital or data had been recorded as at October 2026.

India activities

India's engagement with Burundi's digital sector is at the level of talks. On 22 June 2026 Isidora Ntakiyiruta, adviser to the Ministry of Finance, Budget and Economic Planning, met India's representative to Burundi, Upender Singh Rawat, to discuss cooperation on digital government services, digital identity and e-payments, framed around public-service delivery and financial inclusion. The subject is whether Burundi can adapt India's own model of digital identity linked to instant payments for its national infrastructure; nothing had been agreed or built as at June 2026.

Digital sovereignty

Burundi's social-protection register now runs on open-source software hosted by the state: the Merankabandi social-protection programme replaced its management information system with the open-source CORE-MIS, hosted by the government at the state ICT agency SETIC, with project and government staff running both production and test environments and local teams trained in setup, deployment and maintenance (January 2026). Travel documents went the same way earlier: production has been entirely nationally operated since the Contec Global contract lapsed, with a new supplier contracted only for production inputs (March 2023).

The wider hosting record is older. Ministry ICT focal points questioned in May 2021 whether SETIC could be trusted with state data, and ministries were then hosting their websites on foreign servers although SETIC offered hosting free. The 2026 data-protection law restricts transfers of personal data to jurisdictions without adequate protection or approved safeguards, which binds personal data rather than state data as such. No instrument fixing where state data is held or under whose law it is processed was in force as at September 2026.

The interior ministry presented the biometric identity platform in May 2026 as ready to produce cards. Where the national identity database is hosted, and under whose jurisdiction, had not been published as at September 2026.

Regionally, Burundi takes part in the East African Community's data work, calling in June 2026 for harmonised data-exchange frameworks for interoperable cross-border public services.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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